world constituency insofar as equity and fairness are concerned. This divergence is reflected in trade, climate change and intellectual property positions. As each party tries to frame issues and set priorities to its advantage, these contradictions will continue. India has a powerful constituency in the global South that it must cultivate even as it rises. It would be a more South-Western power than the West may desire.

In the world of security and politics, India sometimes suffers collateral damage of Western initiatives. A case to the point was the Afghanistan jihad in the 1980s that went on to fuel terrorism in Jammu and Kashmir. Developments in Afghanistan and West Asia remain of concern even today. Perceptions and priorities can also differ significantly if vantage points are not the same. On nuclear proliferation, the Western focus on Iran and North Korea stands out in contrast to the whitewashing of Pakistan and the fairy tale of a private A.Q. Khan network. On the question of civil liberties and human rights, a military regime to India's East – in Myanmar- was sanctioned at the very time when one to its West – in Pakistan – was hailed as an ally. When it came to the great tragedies of our era, whether it is the famine in China or mass killings in Bangladesh and Cambodia, strategic calculations of the West trumped public outrage. Old habits explain why the countries that contribute troops to UN peacekeeping have little say in the mandates. Or that the bombing of an Air India aircraft off Ireland is treated so differently from that of PanAm over Lockerbie four years later. We have seen societies that overlook advocacy of terrorism in the name of free speech then practise rendition when their own security is at stake.

There are lessons for both India and the West to draw from these examples. For all the changes in the world, India should not underestimate the influence that the West still retains. On its part, the West should appreciate that India is coming from a different place with a different history. There will inevitably be some divergences, even as the common ground expands.

The key to Western durability till now is the set of institutions and practices that it progressively but firmly established in the period of its dominance. There is virtually no sector of human activity that in some form or the other is not shaped or regulated by it. Rules are set for the entire world, as well as for the global commons. These are supported by narratives that serve the